Pallava architecture can be classified as

1. Rock-Cut temples – Mahendravarman style
2. Monolithic Rathas and Sculptural Mandapas – Mamallan style
3. Structural Temples – Rajasimhan style and Nandivarman style

Mahendra Style

The best example of MahendraVarma style monuments are cave temples at Mandagapattu, Mahendravadi, Mamandur, Dalavanur, Tiruchirapalli, Vallam, Tirukazhukkundram and Siyamangalam.



Cave Temple Mandagapattu

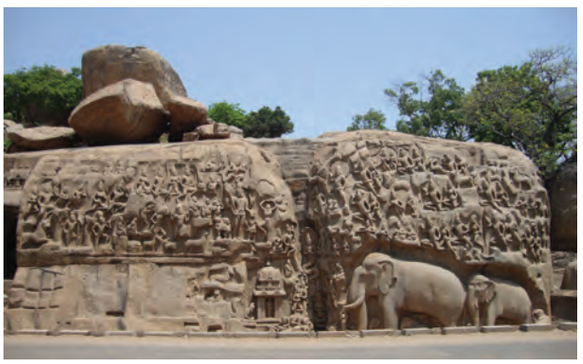
Mamalla Style

The five *rathas* (chariots), popularly called Panchapandavar rathas, signify five different style of temple architecture. Each ratha has been carved out of a single rock. So they are called monolithic. The popular mandapams (pillared pavilions) they built are Mahishasuramardhini mandapam, Thirumoorthi mandapam and Varaha mandapam.



Panchapandavar Rathas

The most important among the Mamalla style of architecture is the open art gallery. Several miniature sculptures such as the figure of lice-picking monkey, elephants of huge size and the figure of the ascetic cat have been sculpted beautifully on the wall of a huge rock. The fall of the River Ganga from the head of Lord Siva and the Arjuna's penance are notable among them. The Great Penance panel is considered to be the world's largest open-air bas relief.



Arjuna's Penance

Rajasimha Style

Narasimhavarma II, also known as Rajasimha, constructed structural temples using stone blocks. The best example for the structural temple is Kailasanatha temple at Kanchipuram. This temple was built by using sand stones. Kailasanatha temple is called Rajasimheswaram.



Kanchi Kailasanatha Temple

6th Std History_Term 3_EM_Unit4.indd 131 06-11-2019 11.07.58 AM